



Make it a Game Changer

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Education is one of the greatest opportunities for India today where we need to pay immediate attention and put substantial amount of resources in. This is really a game-changer for India if we do it right. A fundamental issue is that we have 550 million people who are below the age of 25 and as a result the demand for education has increased substantially. Indian parents too want to spend whatever is required for the best possible education for their children. Today, the education paradigm has changed because of technology—the Internet, computers, fibre optics and mobile-phones. Even the learning methods have changed and this gives us a unique opportunity to redefine education.

Unfortunately, today all universities and even schools are designed on a 100-year-old concept. When we think of schools, we automatically think of duster, blackboard, chalk, textbooks, exams, grades and certificates. But this doesn't hold meaning anymore. So we have a unique opportunity to redefine education for the world and not just for ourselves. But that requires a whole new thinking. It's not about providing the same kind of education like in the US, Germany, Japan and everywhere else and building campuses in 100 acres of land.

We need to make a level-playing field as we did in the telecom sector. One of the Knowledge Commission's recommendations is to make private parties come into education because there is no way the Government can meet the demand. But how do we bring them in? That is why we have recommended a higher education regulatory authority or a higher education commission. You need to go beyond institutions that were set up 50-60 years ago like the University Grants Commission. You need to bring in more flexibility.

Today, it is very difficult to enter because of rules and regulation and also corruption. And once you enter and get a licence, you can provide poor quality. It should be the opposite. It should be easy to enter. Anybody who wants to start colleges or schools

should be allowed to, but he must maintain quality. If those are not met, you can close it down. We need to change the paradigm. I don't know why there is a debate on privatisation of higher education—we have had this tradition for a long time now with so many private colleges already being established. It is in front of our eyes.

You also need flexibility to go from school to vocational education and from there to higher education. Today we don't have seamless mobility. If you go to vocational educating, you are stuck. I can't get a degree in welding or a diploma and then get a Ph.D. in metallurgy. I need that flexibility. Though we have huge opportunities, we haven't focused on vocational education at all. It's not just teaching a welder or a plumber; you need to provide tools as well to empower them. So all this has to be connected; and then also tell them that this is not the dead end. This is a way to earn money now and from here you can earn a Ph.D. if you want. We need to get public-private partnerships in vocational education. Ultimately the output of vocational education would help in growing industry. Industry should pay for it, they are the customers. Why should the Government pay for training all these guys and industries get it for free?

Our real challenge also lies in our ability to use technology, distance learning in an effective way to improve productivity, efficiency, reduce costs and improve access. Apart from the right to education we need to ensure that our schools are modernised and children find it interesting to go to school. We have to make school education entertaining, interesting, rewarding. It's not about building more of the same schools. Today the mind-set is, go get land and erect buildings. It is not about hardware, it's about software—content, new courses and things that will lead to skills. Access to education will change the aspirations of people. We must now restructure the delivery system as the existing machinery just can't do it. You can't expect miracles unless you do that.

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